Populists may deliberately withhold or manipulate data to impede IOs' work. This can involve selectively reporting data to create a distorted picture of reality, outright lying, or altering information to fit political narratives. Appointing loyalists to key bureaucratic positions ensures that the information supplied serves political rather than technical or scientific ends (Oliver and Wood 2014; Busby, Gubler, and Hawkins 2019). For instance, populists might submit incomplete or misleading reports to evade scrutiny, banking on the assumption that IOs lack the resources to investigate thoroughly. This tactic can shield populist governments from accountability while sowing distrust in the IO's processes. Chapter 3 provided evidence consistent with this form of information suppression.

Populists may also seek to discredit alternative sources of information, casting doubt on their reliability and creating confusion about which data can be trusted. This approach undermines the perceived legitimacy of IOs and weakens their ability to enforce compliance (Oreskes and Conway 2011).[5]

Populists often use indirect strategies as well, such as degrading domestic information-collection systems, thereby curtailing the flow of data to IOs. This may involve cutting funding for scientific or statistical agencies, dismissing or politicizing experts, or changing the mandates of agencies responsible for data collection (Potter 2021). These actions appeal to populists' preference for loyal bureaucracies that uncritically implement their policies, as opposed to expert bureaucrats who might challenge their decisions (Bellodi, Morelli, and Vannoni 2024, 5).

The result is a decline in the overall quality of bureaucracy and governance, which inevitably affects the quantity and quality of information available to IOs (Bellodi, Morelli, and Vannoni 2024, 25). This pattern is evident across the ideological spectrum. These strategies leave IOs without reliable data or force them to rely on information so distorted that it can become unusable. In some cases, populists' broader anti-IO policies exacerbate the problem. Cutting funding to IOs or withdrawing entirely from membership (though rare) can further reduce the organization's ability to obtain necessary information (von Borzyskowski and Vabulas 2019b).

Populists weigh several factors when deciding how to obstruct information flows. First, they consider the feasibility of manipulation. The extent to which data can be falsified without raising suspicion varies; for